

ten a letter to the party leadership, pointing out the "lack of correlation between performance and rewards". This was after many of the party's Central leaders who ran its election campaign were absolved of all responsibility for the defeat and allowed to continue in their posts. His ire was particularly aimed at Arun Jaitley, the party's campaign manager who, far from being punished, was made leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, a post vacated by Jaswant when he moved to the Lower House. Such inconvenient truths were left unaddressed even at the Chintan Baithak which was packed with those who led the party to two successive Lok Sabha defeats. The leadership was ingenious enough to devise a formula which saw S.S. Ahluwalia, a former Rajiv loyalist and an import from the Congress who is a deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, being invited for the Shimla conclave while old party hands, like Shanta Kumar, Kalraj Mishra, Yashwant Sinha and Arun Shourie who could have raised a few uncomfortable questions, were deliberately kept out.

The current feeling in the RSS seems to be that the BJP would not have been caught in the current mess if Advani had not strayed from the core ethos of the BJP in the summer of 2005 and tried to transform it into an inclusive outfit that he thought would find more acceptability. The move to broaden the party's base didn't get the party more votes; it only alienated its traditional voters. Advani got away lightly. He gave up his party presidency for a while

but was soon back at the helm. Jaswant is no Advani and the swift retribution is as unambiguous a message as any that those who do not fall in line with Hindutva, do not oppose Article 370, support the Ayodhya movement and back the demand for a uniform civil code have no place in it.

The idea of Advani hasn't worked, and his chosen and trusted team—of which Jaswant was an important cog—has failed to deliver: the leader himself is weakened. An internal report circulated among senior members at the Shimla meeting pointed to the many ills plaguing the party that led to its disastrous electoral outing earlier this year. Among them: lack of unity among top leaders who were all accused of trying to outshine one another; poor management of allies and the media; Advani's ill-advised personal attacks on Manmohan Singh; the failure to market the party's achievements during its last tenure and a failure to pin down the UPA Government over 26/11. It seems the party has learnt little from its past mistakes.

Besides, there is a feeling that the last decade has been one of dilution and decay for the party which seemed to have forgotten its core issues. On top of it, the dominant played by the urban, suave leaders at

IF ADVANI GOES, SO WILL OTHERS
WHO BASKED IN HIS REFLECTED GLORY
AND LEADERS WHO WALKED THE BEATEN
RSS TRACK WILL HAVE ITS BACKING.

**JAITLEY, ANANTH KUMAR,
ADVANI AND M. VENKAIAH NAIDU**



SIPRA DAS